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Founding team gender diversity and social entrepreneurship: implications for venture growth and equity acquisition

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Abstract

Purpose – This study addresses the intersection of team gender composition, social entrepreneurship and new venture performance, aiming to understand the unique dynamics shaping these areas. The authors discuss why female and diverse founding teams often gravitate toward social ventures and explore the relevance of this phenomenon. By investigating the impact on new venture performance, this study examines the effect of team diversity in the context of social entrepreneurship.

Design/methodology/approach – The study is based on a survey among new ventures in Austria. Data from 326 new ventures were analyzed using linear and logistic regression analysis. Drawing on gender role theory, the effect of diverse and female founding teams on the amount of acquired external capital was tested, emphasizing how social goals may serve as a signaling mechanism to investors.

Findings – In line with gender role theory, the study confirms that female and diverse founding teams are more inclined to establish social ventures. While the authors find empirical support for this assertion, there was no evidence found for a second assertion by the gender role theory stating that social entrepreneurship can specifically reduce gender bias with respect to external equity funding of new ventures. Contrary to expectations, the tendency of female and diverse founding teams to prioritize social goals hinders their ability to secure external equity. Furthermore, this research indicates that gender-diverse and all-female teams achieve lower levels of employment growth compared to all-male teams. These results provide insights into the relationship between team composition and venture performance.

Originality/value – Adding to gender role literature, this research expands the current understanding of how team gender diversity and social entrepreneurship affect venture performance. The study indicates a high prevalence of social entrepreneurship among gender-diverse teams and highlights specific challenges faced by female and gender-diverse founding teams. The findings underpin the need for a deeper understanding of the challenges faced by female and gender-diverse teams in the entrepreneurship area. By addressing these dynamics, the study offers valuable insights and recommendations for policymakers, investors and entrepreneurs, laying a foundation for future research into promoting gender equality and fostering inclusive entrepreneurship ecosystems.

Keywords Entrepreneurship, Female entrepreneurs, Social entrepreneurship, Gender

Paper type Research paper

1. Introduction

An increasing body of literature highlights the importance of team diversity for the development and performance of new ventures (Gilbert *et al.*, 1999; Horwitz and Horwitz, 2007; Pelled *et al.*, 1999). Despite extensive research on team diversity, the role of gender diversity in entrepreneurial performance remains inconclusive, with some studies finding positive or

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neutral effects. For instance, Dautzenberg (2012) and Box and Larsson Segerlind (2018) report no significant impact of gender diversity on venture success, while other studies (Apesteguia *et al.*, 2012; Hellerstedt *et al.*, 2007; Neumeyer and Santos, 2020) report that gender-diverse teams outperform all-male and all-female teams in terms of team dynamics, innovativeness and access to venture capital (Apesteguia *et al.*, 2012; Dai *et al.*, 2019). Recent work also emphasizes the signaling effects of gender diversity, which can impact funding opportunities and highlight structural challenges faced by gender-diverse teams (Engel *et al.*, 2023).

While gender-diverse boards have a positive impact on firm performance (Puntaier *et al.*, 2022), women remain underrepresented and face disadvantages in acquiring external equity (Kanze *et al.*, 2018), growing their businesses (Cliff, 1998; Gundry and Welsch, 2001) and building the networks necessary for entrepreneurial success (Brush *et al.*, 2019). Additionally, studies indicate that female entrepreneurs are often better positioned within social enterprises, as the values of these ventures frequently align with societal expectations for female leadership (Sahasranamam *et al.*, 2024). This suggests that gender-diverse teams may experience similar challenges, although findings are not yet conclusive.

This study aims to clarify how gender team composition, specifically gender-diverse and all-female founding teams, influences the type of venture created—social or commercial—and how these choices impact venture performance outcomes. Social ventures are distinguished by their focus on generating social value for specific communities rather than prioritizing profit maximization (Phillips *et al.*, 2015). Research highlights an increasing prevalence of social ventures (Yang *et al.*, 2020), often led by female entrepreneurs who are motivated by communal values and societal benefit. However, it remains uncertain whether these trends also apply to gender-diverse founding teams.

Social ventures often face challenges in securing external funding compared to commercial ventures with profit focus (Certo and Miller, 2008). Equity financing signals the economic potential of the venture (Yang *et al.*, 2020). At the same time, scholars suggest that social entrepreneurship can act as a powerful lever in overcoming gender bias in terms of new venture evaluations (Lee and Huang, 2018). While Pines *et al.* (2012) and Estrin *et al.* (2011) discover a reduced or no gender gap in social entrepreneurship, researchers have yet to analyze the impact of different compositions of gender-diverse teams on social ventures and determine if this positively influences venture performance.

Gender role theory provides a valuable framework for understanding why gender-diverse and female-led teams might be inclined toward social entrepreneurship. According to this theory, women are often associated with communal traits, such as warmth and social responsibility (Eagly, 1987; Eagly and Wood, 2012), which align with the values inherent in social ventures but contrast with the stereotypical entrepreneurial image of risk-taking and self-promotion (Eagly and Karau, 2002). Studies have found that female entrepreneurs are more likely to emphasize social and environmental values, reflecting motivations that align with collective well-being and empowerment (Hechavarría *et al.*, 2012; Ng *et al.*, 2022).

Building on this, recent research highlights that gender-diverse and female-led teams may use social entrepreneurship as a *signaling mechanism* to attract positive investor attention, as social objectives align with societal expectations for women in leadership roles (Lee and Huang, 2018; Engel *et al.*, 2023). Calás *et al.* (2009) further suggest that social entrepreneurship enables women to challenge gendered expectations by reframing entrepreneurship as a form of social change. Teasdale *et al.* (2011) additionally note that women in social enterprises often take on leadership roles, prioritizing social impact over profit. These findings indicate that social entrepreneurship provides a context in which female-led teams and potentially gender-diverse teams can leverage communal values, using them to overcome challenges in traditional entrepreneurial contexts. This study examines how the gender composition of founding teams influences their alignment with social values and, subsequently, the performance outcomes, particularly in terms of external equity acquisition. Therefore, this study compares the outcomes of all-female, gender-diverse and all-male teams, investigating whether social goals mediate the relationship between team gender composition

and performance. The authors propose that social entrepreneurship may help female entrepreneurs mitigate gender bias in venture evaluations (Lee and Huang, 2018). Additionally, the study explores whether gender-diverse teams, as opposed to only all-female teams, have a higher propensity to establish social ventures. Austria provides an ideal setting for this study, as it exhibits high levels of female entrepreneurship and social venture creation compared to other countries (Wilkinson, 2015; Dömötör *et al.*, 2022).

By examining the distinct impact of gender-diverse and female-led teams on venture type and performance, this study contributes to entrepreneurship literature, particularly in the context of social entrepreneurship. This research challenges traditional gender role assumptions and offers new insights into overcoming gender biases within entrepreneurial contexts. Using a sample of 326 Austrian ventures, the authors analyze the implications of gender diversity for venture growth and equity acquisition, ultimately contributing to gender role theory by demonstrating how gender diversity and social objectives intersect with entrepreneurial outcomes.

2. Theoretical background and hypotheses development

2.1 Female and gender-diverse founding teams and their impact on performance

The inclusion of women in entrepreneurship has gained more acceptance worldwide, empirical studies on challenges and performance remain fragmented. While some authors argue that gender does not significantly impact venture success (Kalleberg and Leicht, 1991), others indicate that women-led ventures are generally less successful in terms of raising venture capital, generating sales and growing employment (Amatucci and Sohl, 2004; Fairlie and Robb, 2009). Research suggests that this may be due to factors such as less prior work experience in relevant industries or family businesses (Fairlie and Robb, 2009), as well as differing approaches to business (Brush, 1992). Business is rather seen as a cooperative network of relationships than a segregated unit, which is integrated into their life. Gender stereotypes still lead to disadvantages for women entrepreneurs due to the fact that they are not associated with a professional role of entrepreneurship (Eagly and Karau, 2002; Ramadani, 2015). The "think entrepreneur – think male" paradigm was also supported in a recent study by Laguía *et al.* (2022). Confirming this paradigm, successful entrepreneurs were perceived as more task-orientated (stereotypically masculine) than relationship-oriented (stereotypically feminine) (Laguía *et al.*, 2022).

Performance is widely examined in entrepreneurship research and is operationalized through various indicators, including milestones, venture survival, growth rate, profit or innovation (Baum *et al.*, 2000; Zhou and Rosini, 2015). The most commonly used indicators are sales growth and employee count (Kuschel *et al.*, 2018; Zhou and Rosini, 2015). Given this emphasis, this study adopts employment growth as a performance measure (Santisteban and Mauricio, 2017). Interestingly, while the study by Coad and Timmermans (2014) found that male-led ventures have higher sales and profits, but do not increase human resources, it has been noted by numerous studies that female-led ventures grow less quickly (Cliff, 1998; Isaksen and Kolvereid, 2005; Welter, 2001). Women prefer stable development rather than fast-growing businesses and male-dominated industries (e.g. digital future-oriented industries) have more growth potential than female-dominated areas (Brush *et al.*, 2008).

The process of starting a new venture is typically accompanied by a high level of uncertainty and volatility. Research suggests that entrepreneurial teams, particularly those with diverse compositions, may handle these challenges more effectively than single founders. Beckman and Burton (2008) argue that diverse founding teams bring varied experiences and cognitive approaches that enhance adaptability in unpredictable environments, a crucial factor for growth in new ventures. Additionally, Harrison and Klein (2007) note that diversity respectively variety can foster creative problem-solving and balanced decision-making, both essential for the growth and innovation needed in new ventures. Supporting these findings, Apesteguia *et al.* (2012) note that all-female teams are often outperformed by mixed-gender teams, partly due to enhanced decision-making processes. In addition, studies argue that

diverse teams are more creative, which is important for the success of innovative ventures (Østergaard *et al.*, 2011). Neumeyer and Santos (2020) found that gender-diverse teams perform better when there is a high proportion of female members on the team, benefiting from increased communication frequency and reduced subgroup formation. This leads us to expect a specific ranking in relation to the growth rates of new ventures:

H1a. The level of gender diversity in founding teams is positively associated with the growth rate of ventures, with gender-diverse teams achieving higher growth rates than all-male teams, and all-male teams achieving higher growth rates than all-female teams.

Persistent gender stereotypes contribute to disadvantages for women entrepreneurs particularly concerning acquiring financial capital (Eagly and Karau, 2002; Lins and Lutz, 2016). Acquiring external equity is critical for the success of new ventures, yet female-founded teams tend to receive less funding due to various direct and indirect factors, including perceived confidence and network limitations (Verheul and Thurik, 2001; Brush *et al.*, 2008). Stereotypes often question women's ambition and long-term commitment in competitive markets, which may limit investor confidence and contribute to lower funding levels, especially for all-female teams (Kanze *et al.*, 2018; Malmström *et al.*, 2017). Gender-diverse teams, while benefiting from a blend of perspectives, still face intermediate challenges. Although diversity can signal adaptability and inclusivity, it may also heighten investor concerns about cohesion and strategic alignment (Engel *et al.*, 2023; Uzuegbunam *et al.*, 2021). Beckman and Burton (2008) state that all-male teams often align more closely with traditional venture capital expectations, reinforcing their advantage in accessing capital. Consequently, while mixed-gender teams may experience fewer disadvantages than all-female teams, all-male teams are often favored by investors who associate them with typical entrepreneurial attributes such as competitiveness and assertiveness (Brush *et al.*, 2008; Richard *et al.*, 2004). This suggests that investor bias not only prevents gender equality but also affects access to essential resources, highlighting the need to address these biases in investment decision-making processes.

H1b. The level of gender diversity in founding teams is positively associated with the amount of external equity capital acquired by ventures, with all-female teams acquiring less funding than gender-diverse teams, and gender-diverse teams acquiring less funding than all-male teams.

2.2 Team gender diversity and its impact on the creation of social ventures

Social entrepreneurship has received growing attention in recent years as it has been identified as a powerful and important tool to improve gender equality in the field of entrepreneurship (Bosma *et al.*, 2016; Huysentruyt, 2014). Despite this development, academic research regarding the relationship between social entrepreneurial intentions and gender (Hechavarría *et al.*, 2012, 2017), and especially the relationship between gender and the performance of social ventures (Lee and Huang, 2018; Lortie *et al.*, 2017), remains nascent. Therefore, this study aims to bridge the gap by investigating how gender shapes venture choices (social or commercial). In contrast to commercial entrepreneurship, which is characterized by profit motives (Zahra *et al.*, 2009), the definition of social entrepreneurship varies in the literature (Austin *et al.*, 2012; Bacq *et al.*, 2013; Saebi *et al.*, 2019). For this study, the authors refer to the definition of social entrepreneurship of the Global Entrepreneurship Monitor (GEM), which defines social entrepreneurship as "any kind of activity, organisation or initiative that has a particularly social, environmental or community objective" (Bosma *et al.*, 2016, p. 9). Although social and commercial ventures can pursue overlapping goals, this study distinguishes between them based on their primary missions, with social ventures prioritizing community benefit (Nugroho *et al.*, 2019).

In contrast to the prevailing gender gap in commercial entrepreneurship, scientific research in the field of social entrepreneurship discloses a reduced (Pines *et al.*, 2012) or no gender bias (Estrin *et al.*, 2011). The voluntary sector and nonprofit organizations provide more opportunities for women (van Ryzin *et al.*, 2009) and female entrepreneurs often demonstrate a stronger commitment to societal missions when developing and commercializing new products or services (Hechavarría *et al.*, 2017; Ruskin *et al.*, 2016). This reduction in gender disparity within social entrepreneurship can be attributed to gender-specific characteristics and social expectations. Women are frequently associated with communal traits, such as affection, helpfulness, compassion and nurturance, which align well with the altruistic and community-oriented values inherent in social ventures. Social entrepreneurs are not only recognized for entrepreneurial traits such as innovation and risk-taking (Peredo and McLean, 2006; Sharir and Lerner, 2006) but also often characterized by qualities like altruism, a passion for social change and compassion (Drayton, 2002; Ruskin *et al.*, 2016). Recent studies suggest that social entrepreneurship can serve as a signaling mechanism, especially for gender-diverse and female-led teams, helping them to attract positive investor attention by aligning with societal expectations for women in leadership roles. Research by Engel *et al.* (2023) highlights that gender-diverse teams signal adaptability and inclusivity, attributes that align well with the values of social ventures and can enhance investor confidence. Additionally, Lee and Huang (2018) argue that social goals may help female-led social ventures mitigate gender biases by aligning venture objectives with traditional feminine stereotypes, such as nurturance and community focus, potentially fostering a more favorable evaluation from investors.

According to gender role theory, individuals are rewarded when their actions align with the expectations of their socially ascribed gender roles, while deviations from these roles can lead to penalties (West and Zimmerman, 1987). Women who prioritize social value creation over purely economic goals may do so partly to conform to socially acceptable gender norms, thus achieving higher levels of social acceptance (Eagly and Karau, 2002; Hechavarría *et al.*, 2017). In commercial entrepreneurship, women often face a "lack of fit" due to the incongruence between stereotypically male traits (e.g. competitiveness, risk-taking) and traditionally feminine qualities, which can result in gender penalties and reduced access to resources (Eagly and Karau, 2002). By contrast, social ventures allow women entrepreneurs to engage in entrepreneurship in ways that align with communal values and may even capitalize on these traits to signal a unique competitive advantage, thereby potentially reducing gender-related penalties. In line with this, signaling theory suggests that gender-diverse teams, through their alignment with social goals, may attract investors who prioritize corporate social responsibility (CSR) or community impact, helping these teams access external funding more readily (Engel *et al.*, 2023). Therefore, the authors propose that both all-female and gender-diverse teams are more inclined to establish social ventures, leveraging social goals to align with societal expectations and overcome challenges in traditional entrepreneurial contexts:

H2a. All-female founding teams have a higher propensity to create a social venture compared to all-male founding teams.

We also explore whether this tendency extends to gender-diverse teams, where the presence of both male and female members might similarly favor the creation of social ventures due to the balancing of diverse traits and values within the team. According to corporate business literature, a positive link exists between the number of women on the board of directors and the CSR of the company (Bear *et al.*, 2010; Zhang, 2012). This connection is attributed to characteristics often associated with female leadership, such as sensitivity (Williams, 2003), social orientation (Eagly and Johannesen-Schmidt, 2001) and a participative decision-making style (Konrad *et al.*, 2008). Based on these arguments, the authors propose:

H2b. Gender-diverse founding teams have a higher propensity to create a social venture compared to all-male founding teams.

2.3 Team gender diversity, social venturing and the ability to acquire external capital

Like traditional commercial new ventures, social ventures face challenges in acquiring equity investments and growing their business. There is some evidence that social ventures are disadvantaged when it comes to external funding (Certo and Miller, 2008), partly because their focus on social outcomes introduces greater uncertainty. The uncertainty may be further enhanced in gender-diverse teams, where sophisticated team dynamics can lead to concerns among investors regarding the stability and coherence of decision-making within the team. In particular, gender-diverse teams may face greater difficulties in coordinating actions, resolving conflicts and making prompt decisions (Kearney *et al.*, 2009; Joshi and Roh, 2009). This may be perceived by investors as a lack of cohesion or strategic focus, particularly in high-stakes social ventures.

The acquisition of external equity is an important challenge for female-led and gender-diverse new ventures in general and particularly for social ventures. Venture capitalists, who are primarily driven by the expectation of high returns, may exhibit biases against female-led and gender-diverse teams if they perceive social goals as less aligned with profitability. While management team composition is crucial in investment decisions (Gompers *et al.*, 2020), gender diversity within the team can also influence investor perceptions, potentially reducing confidence in the venture's growth and profit potential. Gender-diverse teams may experience lower levels of psychological safety, defined by Edmondson (1999) as the sense of security team members feel when expressing themselves without fear of negative consequences. A lack of psychological safety can hinder open communication and reduce team efficiency, as unresolved perspectives may disrupt cohesion. This perceived lack of cohesion may reinforce investor biases, potentially lowering investor confidence. Consequently, psychological safety and perceived cohesion in gender-diverse teams may serve as alternative mediators affecting the likelihood of securing external capital (Kearney *et al.*, 2009). While social objectives may enhance capital acquisition by aligning with investors' priorities on social impact, they are not typically associated with driving firm growth and may even hinder it, as resources are allocated to socially oriented rather than growth-focused activities. Thus, while they serve as a meaningful mediator for external equity acquisition (Lee and Huang, 2018), they lack relevance for mediating firm growth.

In academic literature two streams of research are named to explain the phenomenon of female founders receiving less external equity: While the entrepreneur-driven stream traces back to the fact that women request less venture capital, the investor-driven stream relates the difference in venture funding to the unconscious bias toward women entrepreneurs in the male-dominant venture capital industry (Kanze *et al.*, 2018; Malmström *et al.*, 2017). In gender-diverse teams, these biases may be amplified if investors perceive diversity as compromising cohesion, leading to concerns about the team's ability to act with a unified strategic vision, particularly in ventures with a social orientation. Building on the investor-driven stream, external equity investment decisions often involve a signaling process between the venture and the investor, leading to evaluations that may be influenced by implicit biases. Social ventures can mitigate some of these biases by emphasizing social impact, which may align with feminine stereotypes like nurturance and empathy (Eagly *et al.*, 2000; Ruskin *et al.*, 2016). According to gender role congruity theory, female-led social ventures may face reduced social penalties because the social mission aligns with societal expectations for female entrepreneurs (Lee and Huang, 2018). This alignment potentially helps gender-diverse and female-led social ventures signal values that appeal to investors who prioritize CSR and social impact, enhancing access to equity capital.

We propose that social goals act as a mediating factor in the acquisition of external equity for both all-female and gender-diverse founding teams. By aligning their objectives with socially congruent gender stereotypes, these ventures may help to reduce bias and foster greater investor confidence.

H3a. Social goals positively mediate the relationship between ventures with all-female founding teams and the level of acquired external equity capital.

H3b. Social goals positively mediate the relationship between ventures with gender-diverse founding teams and the level of acquired external equity capital.

3. Methods

3.1 Sample

The study is based on a survey among new ventures in Austria which was complemented by collecting data about the participating firms by using company material and information. There is no public data available in Austria regarding newly founded innovative traditional commercial and social ventures with high growth ambitions and hence demand for external equity capital. This gap was addressed by a publicly funded database in Austria (Austrian Startup Monitor), which was initiated in 2017 and aims to identify all newly founded ventures in Austria established since 2008, i.e. not older than 10 years (Leitner *et al.*, 2018). The Austrian Startup Monitor identifies new ventures by using various sources such as information about the location of the new venture (e.g. located in a business incubator), reports in the media about new ventures or data about private or public funding of new ventures. In addition, information on new ventures from two existing databases covering Austria, Crunchbase and Dealroom, was used to build the database. In total, by the end of 2018 the database contained 2,280 active startups which were identified in the various sectors irrespective of whether they were a commercial or a social new venture. These 2,280 new ventures were invited to participate in an online survey in 2019. The online survey encompassed questions about the demographics of the founding team, sources of funding, business strategies, markets and performance. In addition, within the survey the firms had to assess whether they pursue social goals. By various measures such as sending out targeted reminders and short phone calls the research team aimed to achieve a high response rate and a balanced sample concerning location, sector, gender composition and age of the company. In total, 326 firms participated in the study and also delivered data about whether the company primarily follows social goals or not (non-profit ventures were not included in the analysis). As mentioned before, this study distinguished between social and commercial ventures according to the current literature (Nugroho *et al.*, 2019; Bosma *et al.*, 2016) defined by the fact that social goals are prioritized alongside profit generation. In a further step, for those companies that claimed to primarily follow social goals, the authors collected additional data about the objectives of the venture (e.g. company brochures, web page, annual reports) to further validate whether the companies met the criteria to be considered as a new social venture or not. By using both, information from the survey and by collecting data via secondary sources with respect to classifying companies as commercial or social ventures, the authors aimed also to reduce a possible common methods bias. The authors also checked for a possible non-response bias by comparing the sample with the total population taking into account the location, the sector, gender of the founding team and age which revealed no significant differences between both groups delivering no evidence for a bias.

3.2 Measures

To measure the gender diversity of the founding team the authors used the number of female and male founders as collected within the survey to distinguish between three types of founding teams, namely all-female teams, all-male teams, and gender-diverse founding teams (Box and Larsson Segerlind, 2018). All-female teams were those where a single or more than one female entrepreneur founded a new company and were coded as dummy variable. Gender-diverse founding teams were those firms where at least one female and at least one male founder jointly created a new firm used as a dummy variable, too.

To distinguish between commercial and social ventures, the authors followed the definition of the GEM (Bosma *et al.*, 2016) and identified those ventures that conduct activities that have a particularly social, environmental or community objective. The authors used the GEM survey definition because it is the largest data collection on entrepreneurial activity specifically designed to measure social entrepreneurship across countries (Bacq *et al.*, 2013). The respective assessment was performed independently by two reviewers. In order to define the scope of social, environmental or community objectives, the UN social development goals served as the basis (United Nations, 2016). As the ratio between the social value creation and the earned income strategy in a social enterprise can take different forms, the reviewers also allowed hybrid ventures to be included, regardless of their legal form (Austin *et al.*, 2006; Bacq *et al.*, 2013; Peredo and McLean, 2006). For the dependent variable, the authors followed previous studies and used performance measure related to employment growth (e.g. Burgel *et al.*, 2000). New ventures were asked within the survey to indicate the number of employees in 2018, the year of the survey. The authors calculated the average yearly growth rate of the firms in the sample between the employment at the time of the survey and the employment at start up. Within the survey, information regarding the level of external capital acquired until 2018 was collected. External equity capital was measured as a binary variable. A critical threshold within the sample concerns the amount of funding received. Considering the specifics of the Austrian market with a rather small number of substantial investments the authors defined a threshold of 300,000 euros acquired external capital, which accounted for about one-third of the entire sample. This level is considered a milestone for the company development proof of having convinced a larger investor or more than one investor (e.g. business angel) in the Austrian investment landscape (EcoAustria *et al.*, 2023). According to the Austrian Investing Report 2022 (EcoAustria *et al.*, 2023), the majority of business angels invest less than 300,000 euros in a typical investment, going beyond this level can be seen as a first success in the company's development. Companies that received more than or equal to this threshold were coded as 1 and the other companies were given the value 0.

A number of control variables were included to account for possible confounding effects. Based on the literature review, the authors suggest that firm age is a factor that influences performance as firms, for example, learn more about their markets over time (e.g. Burgel *et al.*, 2000; Leitner and Güldenberg, 2010). Additionally, the authors control for the size of the founding team. Initial constraints in terms of human capital as well as financing are considered to be probably less pronounced if the new venture is founded by more individuals. The number of founders variable counts the number of team members on founding team since the founding and can be a proxy for human capital (Baum and Silverman, 2004). The number of founders is therefore included as control variable (Burgel *et al.*, 2000). Moreover, two sectorial dummy variables are integrated to differentiate between firms that are primarily operating in the IT and software development sector or the life science sector focusing on the largest sectors (Hsu, 2007). Further, the authors controlled for whether the new venture is an academic spinoff. Spinoffs are expected to grow more slowly than other entrepreneurial firms (Saemundsson, 2005). The authors used a dummy variable to separate spinoffs from their counterparts. Location-specific effects are another factor potentially impacting firm performance (e.g. Koellinger, 2008). Vienna was included because the majority of start-ups are created in the Austrian capital, where there is a highly supportive environment such as funding opportunities through the presence of venture capital associations, which could have an impact on performance (EcoAustria *et al.*, 2023).

3.3 Statistical analysis

The authors used linear regression models and logistic regression models to test the hypotheses taking into account the dependent variable. The authors tested the robustness and validity of the model specifications in several distinct ways. The authors assessed the threat of multicollinearity by estimating variance inflation factors (VIFs) across all regression models,

and the authors found that the average VIFs for all variables and interaction terms were well below 1.230 and thus well below the recommended ceiling of 10 (Cohen *et al.*, 2013). In a further step, the authors checked for linearity by plotting diagrams with the residuals versus each predictor and the fitted values for the individual variables, which indicated that linearity is given in the models. Moreover, the authors graphically checked for heteroskedasticity revealing that this is an issue in the employment growth model specification. The authors thus used a robust standard errors model. For both the linear regression models and the logistic regression model the authors removed outliers. For the latter model the authors checked the model fit by employing the Hosmer–Lemeshow test which indicated a good model fit.

For the testing of mediation the authors followed the procedure suggested by Iacobucci (2012) which extends the work of Baron and Kenny (1986) and allows to the use of dichotomous variables within a logistic regression model estimation to assess the significance of the mediation effect.

4. Results

Table 1 depicts the correlations among the variables and the main and standard deviation of the variables. With respect to founding team characteristics and social ventures, the descriptive statistics reveals that 24% of all new ventures have a gender-diverse founding team, and only a minority, namely 10%, have all-female founding teams. About two-thirds of the companies are commercial ventures and one-third are classified as social ventures. The average age of the companies is 2.8 years with an average number of 8.9 employees. The average annual number of new employees is 3.1 and 15% of the new ventures are spin-offs. The majority of the firms (28%) belong to the IT sector which is the largest sector new ventures are engaged in. The second largest sector is Life Sciences with 12%. Almost 50% of the companies are located in Vienna.

In order to test the effect of the founding team characteristics on firm growth, the authors performed a regression model, using the calculated measure for employment growth as dependent variable. In the first model (Model 1, Table 2) the authors entered just the controls and then added the variable social venture (Model 2, Table 2), followed by the founding team characteristics in Model 3 (Table 2). Model 3 demonstrates that, contrary to the expectations, gender-diverse founding teams ($b = -0.303$) achieved lower levels of employment growth. Moreover, the authors found weak evidence that all-female founding teams have achieved lower growth rates than other ventures ($b = -0.114$). In Model 4, the all-male variable was included as the independent variable instead of the diverse founding team, thus having the later factors as reference groups, and found no significant difference between the all-female and diverse founding teams ($b = 0.098$). The authors thus found partly support for Hypothesis 1a.

To check the robustness of the models and explore in more detail the negative effect of the gender-diverse teams on the growth rate, the authors ran some further regression models by assessing separate models for both groups—the commercial and social ventures (not disclosed here). These models confirmed that mixed founding teams achieve lower levels of growth in both groups. However, with regard to female founding teams, the statistics revealed that all-female new ventures do not perform worse or better among the group of social ventures. A negative effect of female teams on the 10%-sig-level holds among the commercial ventures.

Hypotheses 1b deals with the impact on the founding team characteristics and the level of acquired external equity capital. The authors therefore ran a logistic regression model with the dependent variable equity capital (Table 3). The first model contained only the control factors, revealing that the sector, the location and firm age had an impact on the level of equity capital obtained so far. In Model 2, the variables regarding the founding team characteristics were incorporated without taking into account whether the firm was a social venture. In Model 4 the variable social ventures was integrated as well. Both models revealed that gender-diverse teams ($b = -1.325$) and all-female teams ($b = -2.036$) had acquired less external capital (Model 4, Table 3). Next, the authors also performed a model entering all-male and all-female

Table 1. Cross-correlation among the variables

		Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
1	All-female founding teams	0.10	0.29	–									
2	Diverse founding teams	0.24	0.41	−0.191**	–								
3	Social goals	0.36	0.46	0.146**	0.232**	–							
4	Academic spinoffs	0.15	0.37	−0.076	−0.063	0.024	–						
5	Sector IT	0.28	0.45	−0.160**	0.001	−0.244**	−0.013	–					
6	Sector Life Science	0.12	0.32	0.015	−0.078	0.103*	0.080	−0.198**	–				
7	Location (Vienna)	0.47	0.50	−0.08	0.022	−0.042	−0.011	−0.017	−0.023	–			
8	Age	2.78	2.40	−0.087	−0.094*	−0.162**	0.064	−0.187**	0.040	0.025	–		
9	Founding team size	2.44	1.05	−0.177**	0.246**	0.097	0.035	0.072	0.013	0.001	0.341**	–	
10	Employment growth	0.23	0.21	−0.024	−0.178**	−0.062	−0.042	0.022	−0.057	0.109	−0.153*	0.064*	–
11	External equity capital	0.34	0.47	−0.112*	−0.111*	−0.149**	−0.060	−0.027	0.128**	0.135**	0.269**	0.345**	0.232*

Note(s): *$p < 0.05$, **$p < 0.01$, ***$p < 0.001$
Source(s): Created by authors

Table 2. Regression model with dependent variable employment growth (standardized beta)

	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4
Sector IT	0.111†	0.098	0.090	0.090
Sector life science	−0.041	−0.041	−0.079	−0.079
Vienna	0.126*	0.126*	0.144*	0.144*
Founding team size	0.039	0.042	0.087	0.087
Firm age	−0.190***	−0.190***	−0.205**	−0.205**
Academic spin-offs	−0.060	−0.060	−0.090	−0.090
Social goals		−0.051	0.048	0.048
Diverse founding teams			−0.303**	
All-female founding teams			−0.114†	0.098
All-male founding teams				0.303**
F-value	3.057**	2.713***	4.985***	4.985***
Adj. R^2	0.043	0.043	0.115	0.115

Note(s): †$p < 0.10$, *$p < 0.05$, **$p < 0.01$, ***$p < 0.001$
Source(s): Created by authors

Table 3. Logistic regression model with external equity capital (beta)

	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4	Model 5
Sector IT	−0.072	−0.181	−0.348	−0.477	−0.477
Sector Life Science	1.043**	1.047***	1.230**	1.095**	1.095**
Vienna	0.767**	0.860*	0.776*	0.891***	0.891***
Founding team size	0.516***	0.626***	0.612**	0.690***	0.690***
Firm age	0.368***	0.361**	0.375***	0.383**	0.383**
Academic spinoffs	0.133	−0.335	0.154	−0.364	−0.364
Social goals			−1.354*	−0.960**	−0.960**
Diverse founding teams		−1.597**		−1.325***	
All-female founding teams		−2.326**		−2.036**	−0.548
All-male founding teams					1.325***
Constant	−2.050**	−6.542***	−2.342**	−2.770***	−2.770***
Chi	83.925***	67.426***	105.384***	124.013***	124.013***
Log-likelihood	376.096	114.315	346.390	327.760	327.760
Cox & Snell R^2	0.196	0.201	0.242	0.278	0.278

Note(s): *$p < 0.05$, **$p < 0.01$, ***$p < 0.001$
Source(s): Created by authors

as independent variable (Model 5, Table 3) in order to test a possible difference between all-female and gender-diverse teams, revealing no significant difference (b = −0.548). Thus, the authors found partly support for Hypothesis 1b, indicating that both all-female and gender-diverse founding teams underperform compared to all-male teams, while no significant performance difference was observed between all-female and diverse teams.

To test Hypothesis 2, which proposed that all-female and gender-diverse founding teams have a higher likelihood of establishing new social ventures, the authors conducted a logistic regression model with the variable social venture as dependent variable (see Table 4). The authors first entered the team gender characteristics in the model (Table 4, Model 1) and then integrated the controls to account for any other factors that might have an influence on the venture type, i.e. a commercial or social venture. The model delivered evidence that both all-female (b=1.476, Model 2) and gender-diverse founding teams (b=1.322, Model 2) more often than all-male ventures establish social ventures, wherefore Hypotheses 2a and 2b are supported. In addition, the authors found evidence that in the IT sector social ventures are established less often.

Table 4. Logistic regression model with dependent variable social startup (beta)

	Model 1	Model 2
Diverse founding teams	1.433***	1.476***
All-female founding teams	1.454***	1.322***
Sector IT		−1.528***
Sector life science		0.617
Vienna		−0.291
Founding team size		0.185†
Age		−0.067
Academic spinoffs		0.520
Constant	−1.736***	0.472
Chi	41.324***	79.921***
Log-likelihood	461.691	423.094
Cox and Snell R^2	0.101	0.187

Note(s): †$p < 0.10$, *$p < 0.05$, **$p < 0.01$, ***$p < 0.001$
Source(s): Created by authors

Table 5 provides additional findings and compares in more detail some differences between social and commercial ventures, thereby confirming again that gender-diverse and all-female teams are more inclined to establish social ventures. As social ventures are more often established by mixed teams the founding team size is larger than in new commercial ventures, too. The comparison of the means show that commercial ventures are larger than social ventures with respect to the number of employees and are also able to acquire external equity capital exceeding 300,000 euros (42% in the group of commercial ventures, 24% in the group of social ventures) significantly more often.

In order to test a possible mediation effect as proposed by Hypothesis 3, the authors conducted a few tests. The authors followed the procedure by Baron and Kenny (1986), who suggested performing a few consecutive steps, which was complemented by an additional analysis as suggested by Iacobucci (2012). As already reported above, there was a positive significant relationship between the causal variable female founders and the mediator social ventures (See Table 4). This is the first condition that must be met to prove a possible mediation effect. In addition, there must be a direct positive effect between the causal variable, i.e. female founders, and the outcome variable, i.e. level of external equity capital. Model 2 (Table 3) integrated the founding team characteristics without considering social goals which reveals a negative effect for all-female founding teams (b = −2.326). Next, the relationship between the

Table 5. Characteristics of social ventures

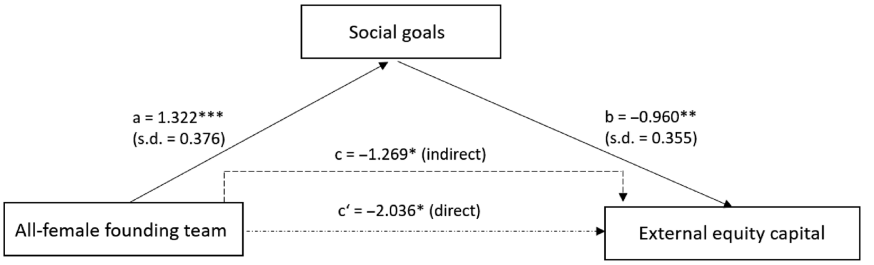
	Commercial ventures	Social ventures	Chi-Square/*t*-value
Diverse founding teams	17.5%	37.1%	21.081***
All-female founding teams	7.1%	14.5%	9.211**
All-male founding teams	75.4%	48.8%	36.957***
Founding team size	2.35	2.62	−2.150*
Age	3.11	2.29	3.152**
Size (Employees)	10.83	4.59	3.301**
Academic spinoffs	14.6%	16.1%	0.167
Sector IT	34.5%	38.5%	27.897***
Sector life science	7.7%	13.4%	3.574†
External equity capital (>300t Euro)	42%	24%	9.164**

Note(s): †$p < 0.10$, *$p < 0.05$, **$p < 0.01$, ***$p < 0.001$
Source(s): Created by authors

mediator variable social goals and its impact on the outcome needed to be evaluated. Model 3 (Table 3) integrated the variable social goals showing a negative effect (b = −1.354) on external equity. When incorporating both, female founders and social startups simultaneously in the regression model (Model 4, Table 3), the coefficient for the female founders slightly drops (b = −2.036) delivering evidence for a partial mediation effect of social goals. In order to assess the significance of the mediation effect the authors followed the procedure proposed by Iacobucci (2012) to cope with the dichotomous mediator and outcome variables. Iacobucci's approach is a modified and extended procedure proposed by Sobel (1982) and Baron and Kenny (1986). Following this procedure, the direct effect of the mediator variable social goal on external capital in the full model has to be estimated which is −0.960 (Model 4, Table 3). The indirect effect is the product of the effect of the mediator, i.e. social goals, on the outcome variable (b = −0.960), and the effect of the causal variable, i.e. all-female founding teams on the mediator (b = 1.322), which accounts for −1.269. Finally, for this effect the confidence intervals and the z-value can be calculated using the standard deviation of the variables, which is 2.091 and above the cut-off point of 1.960, assuming a 95% confidence interval and a two-tailed test. The amount of mediation, the difference between the indirect and direct effect, can be calculated as well, which accounts for 0.767. Figure 1 summarizes the relationships between founding team characteristics, social goals and the outcome variable equity capital with the indirect (c = −1.269) and direct effect (c' = -2.036). Thus, contrary to the expectation, the authors found a negative partial mediation effect and hence no support for Hypothesis 3a.

Furthermore, the authors adopted the procedure as described above to test whether the impact of gender-diverse teams on equity acquisition is mediated by social goals. This analysis (not disclosed) revealed a significant partial mediation effect (indirect effect c = −1.417; direct effect c' = -1.325). Therefore, Hypothesis 3b must be rejected.

The analysis of the new ventures is particularly challenged by a possible survival bias when conducting a survey. The authors thus conducted some post hoc analysis to examine whether the founding team characteristics might have an impact on the success of the company. The Austrian Startup Monitor contains also information about whether companies have failed and closed their business, e.g. due to liquidity problems. This number of firms is higher as the



Note(s): The mediation is tested via a z-test defined as follows (Sobel 1982):

$$z = \frac{a\ x\ b}{\sigma_{ab}} = \frac{a\ x\ b}{\sqrt{b^2 s_a^2 + a^2 s_b^2}}$$

where the numerator $a\ x\ b$ is the estimated size of the indirect effect c, σ_{ab} is its standard error, and $z \sim N(0;1)$; i.e., there is a significant mediated effect if z exceeds $\left| 1.96 \right|$ for 2-tailed tests with $\alpha = 0.05$. *$p < 0.05$, **$p < 0.01$, ***$p < 0.001$

Source(s): Created by authors

Figure 1. Social goals mediating the effect of all-female founding teams on the level of external equity capital

companies contacted for the survey were only those which were active in 2019. For 1,980 new ventures which were founded between 2008 and 2019 information about whether they firm survived or not since their establishment was available. In total, 18% of the companies which were founded between 2008 and 2019 were closed. The authors performed a logistic regression model with the status of the company (survival or failure) as dependent variable and the founding team characteristics, sector, company age, academic spin-off and location of the company as independent variables (see Table A1 on Appendix). While the coefficient for female founders is negative, the coefficient for diverse teams is positive. However, both coefficients are not significant. Thus, there is no evidence that the gender team characteristics has a significant impact on the likelihood to survive which delivers evidence for the robustness of the results.

5. Discussion

This study examined the role of gender in founding teams, analyzing how different team compositions influence venture performance and how social orientation affects success in terms of growth and external equity acquisition. The results revealed different outcomes regarding gender diversity's impact on venture growth and capital acquisition, with gender-diverse and all-female teams more likely to establish social ventures yet often facing challenges in securing external equity.

The finding that gender-diverse teams do not outperform all-male teams in growth and funding aligns with those studies arguing that diverse teams, while innovative, often face coordination and cohesion challenges that can reduce efficiency. Kollmann *et al.* (2017) demonstrate that member differences, especially within gender-diverse teams, can lead to coordination issues and slower decision-making processes, limiting performance potential despite the diversity's theoretical benefits (Kollmann *et al.*, 2017). In resource-constrained environments, these dynamics may further complicate growth-oriented strategies, underscoring the need for cohesive communication frameworks within diverse teams to manage complex interactions.

The results also indicate that all-female and gender-diverse teams exhibit a higher propensity to establish social ventures, a finding supported by gender role theory, which suggests women may prioritize communal and social values over strictly economic objectives (Eagly and Karau, 2002). This aligns with Dickel and Eckardt's (2021) study, which finds that women with strong sustainability orientations are particularly drawn to social entrepreneurship (Dickel and Eckardt, 2021). This perspective could explain why female-led and gender-diverse teams often pursue social ventures, as these goals resonate with communal values associated with feminine stereotypes. However, while social ventures provide a more value-congruent space for female entrepreneurs, they may also encounter limitations in attracting investors, particularly when social goals are perceived as conflicting with financial returns.

Contrary to expectations, these findings suggest that the social penalty associated with women entrepreneurs receiving less external equity is partially negatively mediated when the new venture pursues social goals. Furthermore, there is no evidence that female-led social ventures achieve significantly lower growth rates than those led by all-male teams. Thus, female social entrepreneurs achieve growth rates as high as potential investors would expect from innovative new ventures. Despite this, they still face difficulties in raising external equity funding. Therefore, these findings contradict previous research by Lee and Huang (2018), who found that investors are more likely to provide more financial resources to ventures if their goals are defined in line with the characteristics of a social entrepreneur. Furthermore, this finding contradicts role congruence theory (Eagly, 1987), where women are perceived as unsuitable for the position of an entrepreneur and suitable for building a social venture. These differences can be explained by the disadvantage of social ventures in raising external equity compared to commercial ventures (Certo and Miller, 2008), where it seems that the

congruence of all-female founding teams with their anticipated stereotype cannot outweigh the disadvantage of social ventures in raising external equity.

Investor biases further compound these challenges. According to Block *et al.* (2021) investors prioritize team authenticity, societal impact and financial viability when screening for social enterprises. While gender-diverse and female-led teams align well with societal impact goals, they may struggle to meet financial expectations or convey a balance between profitability and social goals that satisfy investor requirements. This finding underscores the need for gender-diverse teams in social ventures to refine their financial narratives, integrate societal and economic objectives to better align with investor expectations.

The psychological safety within gender-diverse teams, defined by Edmondson (1999) as the comfort team members feel when expressing themselves, may also affect team dynamics and investor perceptions. Low psychological safety can affect communication, reduce efficiency and indirectly reinforce investor biases about team reliability (Kearney *et al.*, 2009). Promoting psychological safety and cohesive decision-making in gender-diverse teams, particularly in social enterprises, is critical to fostering trust and stability.

To address these challenges, investors could benefit from training to mitigate unconscious biases affecting funding decisions, particularly biases related to gender and social impact. Policies incentivizing investment in gender-diverse social ventures or providing resources to strengthen team cohesion and decision-making frameworks could improve funding access for these ventures. Further, targeted support programs for female and gender-diverse entrepreneurs, including mentorship, networking and investor relations training, may enhance their capacity to attract equity funding by presenting a well-rounded value proposition that combines social and financial objectives.

6. Conclusion

This study contributes to understanding the intersections between gender-diverse teams, women's entrepreneurship and social entrepreneurship, revealing persistent gender biases despite various efforts to promote gender equality in Austria's entrepreneurial ecosystem. Notably, the findings confirm the prevalence of social ventures among gender-diverse and all-female teams, contributing to a broader understanding of gender dynamics in entrepreneurship. However, these ventures face significant challenges in securing external equity, highlighting a persistent funding gap. The results reinforce the enduring "think entrepreneur, think male" stereotype (Laguía *et al.*, 2022), emphasizing the need for policies that address and counteract this bias. Although social entrepreneurship appears less affected by gender bias, with gender-diverse and all-female teams predominantly founding social ventures, equal access to resources and support remains challenging (Brush *et al.*, 2019). Moreover, contrary to previous assumptions (Lee and Huang, 2018), social goals do not sufficiently mitigate gender bias in external equity funding, underscoring the need for greater awareness among investors and tailored strategies for addressing these challenges.

From a practical standpoint, entrepreneurs, particularly women and gender-diverse teams, could benefit from targeted support such as mentorship programs, networking opportunities, and guidance on navigating gender biases. The study clarifies the role of social goals as a signaling mechanism, suggesting that while these goals align with traditional female gender roles, they do not necessarily improve access to external funding. This finding adds nuance to gender role theory by showing that alignment with socially accepted roles does not guarantee financial support, highlighting the limits of social goals in mitigating investor bias. Educational programs should include modules on managing diverse team dynamics, emphasizing strategies to enhance cohesion and decision-making effectiveness in gender-diverse teams. Policymakers could consider supporting programs that educate investors on bias and offer incentives for investments in gender-diverse teams or female-led ventures. For venture capitalists, implementing bias-awareness training may help mitigate unconscious stereotypes in decision-making, fostering a more inclusive funding environment.

The study has several limitations that present opportunities for further research. The focus on Austrian firms may limit the generalizability of the findings; extending this research to other countries could reveal if similar biases exist in different cultural and economic contexts. While this study categorizes ventures as either social or commercial, future research could examine nonprofit and hybrid ventures more specifically to determine if team composition affects these types differently. Future research might also explore alternative funding mechanisms, such as crowdfunding or green investment funds, as these may have different gender dynamics due to varying investor priorities. Another area of interest is the role of female investors in venture funding decisions, as their presence may influence the investment process. This study did not consider specific proportions of male and female founders within diverse teams. Measures like the Blau index (Blau, 1977) could better capture nuances in team heterogeneity. With regard to the assessment of the performance of the companies the authors have not dealt with reverse causality and the fact that the growth of a company may affect its ability to obtain finance and vice versa. Finally, incorporating a broader set of performance metrics, such as revenue growth or profitability, would provide a more comprehensive perspective on the impact of gender diversity in founding teams.

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Appendix

Table A1. Logistic regression model (survival of new ventures)

	b
Diverse founding teams	0.222
All-female founding teams	−0.435
Sector IT	0.387†
Sector Life Science	0.636
Age	0.067*
Academic spinoffs	−0.219
Constant	−3.357*
Chi	17.706***
Log-Likelihood	1059.898
Cox and Snell R^2	0.010
N	1.850

Note(s): †$p < 0.10$, *$p < 0.05$, **$p < 0.01$, ***$p < 0.001$
Source(s): Created by authors

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